

Speed Break

INDIA'S 2-0 VICTORY over Australia was not merely an on-field cricketing victory over the strongest team in world cricket, but also a tactical one, in which the medium pacers, Zaheer Khan and Ishant Sharma, picked up 26 wickets between them using conventional and reverse swing to override placid wickets. Team bowling coach Venkatesh Prasad believes the series marks a shift away from an over-reliance on spin at home. "The quicks were responsible for initial breakthroughs. We wanted them to run in hard and hit the crease. That's what they did." Before the series, every bowler was sent cds of Australia's batsmen during their break and asked to develop strategies. Prasad commends his bowlers' 'cricketing intelligence' and their sense of being a team within a team. India's pacemen, he said, would be rotated during ODI series to keep them fit and fresh.

PRASAD BELIEVES THE BORDER-GAVASKAR SERIES MARKS A SHIFT AWAY FROM AN OVER-RELIANCE ON SPIN AT HOME



intent has been unflagging. With the new ball and old, he has generated bounce, reverse swing, jag and more subtle movement asking questions that Australia's most established batsmen have struggled to answer.

For the battered brotherhood of Indian fast bowlers, who labour long and hard in a country obsessed with run-makers, Sharma has become the special one. He, they believe, could be the boy in whose shadow skinny long-haired boys would want to bowl fast.

Less than five years ago, Sharma was himself one of them, chasing the legend of Australian Glenn McGrath. Fast tracked through junior and first-class cricket, he has already shared a bowler-to-bowler conversation with McGrath during the IPL and shoulders the Indian attack with composure and a sense of occasion. It is the smoothness with which he has shifted gears in the fastest lane that has surprised many, though not those in closest proximity to him. "I'm not surprised," says his Delhi Captain Virender Sehwag, "because he was always someone who bowled in good areas and at pace, who beat batsmen on pace rather than swing and seam."

The ability to take that gift onto the international arena has come due to the ability and desire to grasp information and execute new skills. Former pace bowler Javagal Srinath says Sharma is bowling in a zone where he is "creating opportunities against leading batsmen". Srinath believes Sharma speaks of his craft like an experienced practitioner who has understood and internalised patience and the art of building a spell.

It is quite a story: the average son of an average family with an average aptitude for studies turning out exceptional in the most precarious profession of all. In an attempt to get admission into a commerce course in Class XI despite a somewhat humble report card, he ran into his first coach, who worked at the Ganga International School near Delhi's north-western borders. In his first



net, Sharma hit the poles holding up the nets rather than the stumps inside it. Coach Shriram Kumar laughs, "He had good height, he came to me with an action that didn't require any work. He was wayward, that's all." Kumar's cricket centre fixed Sharma's run-up and put him through bowling boot camp—regular three-hour spells. It is why Sharma's appetite to bowl hard and long is matched by his ability to do it. Delhi teammate Aakash Chopra says, "Ishant wants to bowl and he doesn't want to bowl five overs, he wants to bowl 25 overs and keep going." Sehwag says a net against Sharma is like a spell in the middle.

Sharma's natural pace sent him through under-15s, 19s and into the Ranji Trophy within a year; he was picked for under-19 tours of England, Pakistan and New Zealand in 2006-07. When under-19 coach Lalchand Rajput wrote his England tour report, he named Sharma as one of the two from that team who would play for India.

Within a year Sharma was called up for a first team tour of Bangladesh but broke through on the 2007-08 tour of Australia, when he took the injured Khan's place in Sydney and led the attack. Every tour, he has picked up more of his trade, be it a yorker in